

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Biotechnology English

Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For biotech scientists, translational researchers, assay-development teams, platform teams, program managers, alliance managers, business-development staff, and biotech executives.

Fictional language practice for professional communication. Clinical, safety, regulatory, and patient-care decisions follow qualified supervision and current local procedures.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

assay

Laboratory procedure used to measure the presence, amount, activity, or quality of a biological target.

biomarker

Measurable biological characteristic used to indicate a condition, response, exposure, or disease-related process.

CMC

Chemistry, manufacturing, and controls information that shows how a drug substance or product is made and consistently controlled.

comparability

The extent to which products, processes, or results are sufficiently similar for a stated purpose.

due diligence

Structured review of facts, risks, obligations, and evidence before a transaction, onboarding, investment, or decision.

exclusivity

An arrangement limiting specified rights or activities to one party for an agreed scope.

freedom to operate

Assessment of whether a product or activity can proceed without infringing another party's enforceable intellectual-property rights.

in vitro

Performed outside a living organism, typically in a laboratory vessel, cell system, or controlled assay.

in vivo

Performed in a living organism, such as an animal or human study participant.

inflection point

A stage at which the direction or pace of development may change significantly.

IP

Intellectual property: legally recognized rights in certain creations, inventions, and identifying marks.

material transfer agreement

An agreement setting conditions for transferring and using research materials.

milestone

A significant planned point or achievement used to track progress.

modality

A type of therapeutic or technological approach, such as a small molecule or cell therapy.

option

A possible course of action; in an agreement, a specified right that may be exercised.

patient stratification

Grouping patients by characteristics that may affect disease course, treatment response, safety, or trial analysis.

platform

A foundational technology or system that supports several applications or products.

proof of concept

Early evidence that an idea can work under specified conditions.

publication rights

The agreed rights and conditions governing disclosure or publication of work.

reproducibility

Obtaining consistent results using the same data and methods; conventions vary by research field.

risk mitigation

Action intended to reduce the likelihood or impact of a risk.

runway

In business, the time resources are expected to last under stated assumptions; in aviation, a takeoff and landing surface.

safety margin

The difference between a limit and an observed or expected value under a stated definition.

sensitivity

Ability of a test, model, or process to correctly identify true positives or detect a change in an input.

specificity

Ability of a test, model, or process to correctly identify true negatives and avoid false positives.

surrogate endpoint

Measure expected to predict clinical benefit but not itself a direct measure of how a patient feels, functions, or survives.

tech transfer

Controlled transfer of product, process, method, or manufacturing knowledge between teams, sites, or organizations.

term sheet

A summary of proposed transaction terms, whose binding effect depends on its wording and context.

toxicity

The capacity of a substance or exposure to cause harmful biological effects.

translatability

Likelihood that a finding in one model, setting, or population will predict results in the intended real-world or clinical setting.

validation

Confirming that an output or system meets needs for its intended use under defined conditions.

yield

The proportion of production meeting defined requirements; in finance, a return measure with a different calculation.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Explain a fair comparison

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Give a useful status update

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Ask for an actionable next step

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Make a complex point clear

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Offer a workable tradeoff

We can ..., provided that

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Platform Technology and Scientific Thesis

A platform produces a promising signal in one experimental system. An investor slide says it will work across several diseases.

The finding is promising in this experimental system. We have not established its relevance across diseases. I'll distinguish the current evidence from the broader platform hypothesis.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

02 | Assay Development and Reproducibility

An assay gives consistent results within one run but different results across three days. A colleague calls it fully reproducible.

Within-run consistency and performance across days are different questions. Let's report both and investigate the between-day variation before describing the assay as reproducible under those conditions.

Try it again: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

03 | Biomarkers and Translational Strategy

A team calls a biomarker "validated" without specifying whether it means analytical performance or clinical usefulness.

What kind of validation do you mean here? Could we distinguish the assay's analytical performance from evidence about the biomarker's clinical use? The slide needs to state which claim the data support.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

04 | Preclinical Data Packages

An animal study shows an effect at one tested exposure. A summary describes the result as proof of human benefit.

The result describes the tested animal model and exposure. It does not establish human benefit. I'll state the finding and the limits on translating it to a clinical setting.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

05 | CMC and Scale-Up in Biotech

A process transfer achieved the expected yield in two small runs. Performance at a larger scale remains untested.

The two small runs met the expected yield. Larger-scale performance is still untested. I'll present scale-up as an open question and identify the next planned evidence point.

Try it again: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

06 | IP, Freedom to Operate, and Collaboration

Two partners want to exchange materials. The draft arrangement leaves publication and permitted-use questions unresolved.

Could the responsible teams confirm the permitted uses and publication terms before the exchange? I'll summarize the scientific purpose and the unresolved questions for review.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

07 | Investor and Board Updates

A project update lists completed experiments but does not connect them to the next funding milestone.

I'll group the results around the milestone question: what have we learned, what remains uncertain, and what evidence is needed next? That will make the funding discussion easier to follow.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

08 | Partnering and Business Development

A potential partner requests exclusive rights before the scope of the collaboration is defined.

We can discuss exclusivity alongside the proposed scope, responsibilities, and milestones. Could we first clarify which activities and rights you have in mind so the appropriate teams can evaluate the request?

Try it again: The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

Use the language responsibly

Fictional language practice for professional communication. Clinical, safety, regulatory, and patient-care decisions follow qualified supervision and current local procedures.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-06. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Build vocabulary and collocations

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Biotechnology English

Professional audience: biotech scientists, translational researchers, assay-development teams, platform teams, program managers, alliance managers, business-development staff, and biotech executives

Scope: Fictional language practice for professional communication. Clinical, safety, regulatory, and patient-care decisions follow qualified supervision and current local procedures.

Lesson 01: Platform Technology and Scientific Thesis

Original fictional case: A platform produces a promising signal in one experimental system. An investor slide says it will work across several diseases.

Language workshop: Match certainty to evidence

Communication goal: Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

Language guidance: Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): The available evidence shows ... / This may indicate ..., but ... / We have not yet established whether ...

Vocabulary: platform: A foundational technology or system that supports several applications or products. / modality: A type of therapeutic or technological approach, such as a small molecule or cell therapy. / proof of concept: Early evidence that an idea can work under specified conditions. / translatability: Likelihood that a finding in one model, setting, or population will predict results in the intended real-world or clinical setting.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: The finding is promising in this experimental system. We have not established its relevance across diseases. I'll distinguish the current evidence from the broader platform hypothesis.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Vocabulary in use

1. Choose four useful terms from the reference. For each, give a plain-English meaning in this field, two natural word combinations (collocations), one realistic example and a likely misuse or contrast. Keep the examples consistent with the reference and avoid jargon that does not fit this occupation.
2. Add four related terms that would be useful in a different common situation in the same field. Label these as suggested extensions, explain how they connect to the work, and flag regional or organizational variation where relevant. Do not pad the list with synonyms nobody would use at work.
3. Start a retrieval round: give one short workplace sentence with a gap and a clear clue. Ask me to supply the best term and explain my choice. Stop and wait; do not reveal the answer or a completed sentence yet. Accept another term if its meaning and collocation work.
4. After my attempt, explain one useful distinction and ask me to write my own sentence. Wait, correct a genuine meaning or usage problem, then give the next retrieval question. Work through four questions one at a time.
5. Finish with a short handoff or message task using three terms, followed by two recall questions I can save for another day. Do not pretend to schedule a reminder.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Test recall and transfer

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

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END REFERENCE

TASK: A short retrieval session

1. Tell me to close my notes. Plan six questions: two vocabulary-in-context items, one grammar or meaning contrast, one question about a confirmed versus unknown detail, one short spoken-style response and one new-situation transfer task. Use the supplied material as the answer reference, but do not repeat its existing checks word for word.
2. Ask only the first question, then stop and wait. Prefer a short answer over a multiple-choice question. Do not display the remaining questions, model answers or a word bank in advance.
3. After each answer, say what it gets right and explain a meaningful error if there is one. Accept alternative wording when it preserves the facts and does the communication job. If I struggle, give one clue and invite a retry before revealing a model. Only then move to the next question.
4. Keep a simple record of which items I answered independently, with a hint, or after seeing a model. This records today's practice, not a certified proficiency score. Do not judge pronunciation from typed text.
5. At the end, summarize two strengths and two useful next steps with examples from my answers. Give me a small review card containing three prompts and a separate answer section. Suggest that I revisit it tomorrow and a week later; do not claim you will remember this session or send reminders. Label the final transfer scenario as fictional.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level